"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 28

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

- Isaac was born in approximately 1896 B.C. Esau and Jacob were born when Isaac was 60 years old (1836 B.C.). Isaac lived to be 180 years old and died around 1716 B.C. Utilizing details in the upcoming chapters, it seems safe to say the events recorded in Genesis 28 took place between the years 1816-1757 B.C.

Characters:

- Isaac – Abraham's son and husband of Rebekah.
- Rebekah – Isaac's wife and mother of Jacob and Esau.
- Esau – The firstborn of Isaac. He was a skillful hunter (25:27).
- Jacob – The twin brother of Esau. In Genesis 27, he stole Esau's blessing.
- Laban – The brother of Rebekah who lived in Haran.

Where:

- From Genesis 28:10, it appears Isaac, Esau, and Jacob lived in Beersheba. Jacob departed Beersheba and stopped in Bethel before continuing north to Haran.

Outline:

- ISAAC SEND'S JACOB TO HARAN (28:1-5):
    + Isaac and Rebekah did not want Jacob to marry a Canaanite woman.
    + Isaac blessed Jacob and asked the Lord to fulfill His promises to Abraham through Jacob and his descendants.
    + Jacob was instructed to go to Paddan-aram (Haran), to the house of Laban, Rebekah's brother.
- ESAU MARRIES MAHALATH (28:6-9):
    + Esau had previously married at least two Canaanite wives, Judith and Basemath (26:34).
    + When he saw how his parents disliked the Canaanite women, Esau married Mahalath, one of the children of Ishmael (the son of Abraham with Hagar).
- JACOB'S DREAM AND THE LADDER TO HEAVEN (28:10-22):
    + Jacob departed Beersheba and went to Haran.
    + He came to a "certain place" and laid down to sleep, using a stone for a pillow.
    + That night he dreamed of a ladder stretching from earth to heaven and he saw angels ascending and descending the ladder.
    + The Lord stood above the ladder and told Jacob his children would be as numerous as the dust of the earth and all nations would be blessed through them.
    + God promised to be with Jacob on his journey and to eventually bring him back to Canaan.
    + Jacob was stunned by what he saw, and he declared, "This is none other than the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven."
    + In the morning, Jacob made a pillar of stone and anointed it with oil.
    + He named the location Bethel.
    + He vowed that he would worship the God of his father Abraham if God would keep him safe and return him to Canaan one day.

Application:

- When you are confident the Lord is watching over you, it makes it easier to step out into the unknown.
- Jacob was about to make a 500+ mile journey to a land (Haran) he had never seen.
- No doubt the Lord's promise to protect him brought him comfort.
- We all face situations where the future is uncertain, but we can face the future with confidence knowing the Lord is always with His children.
- God has reassured us He will never leave us or forsake us (Hebrews 13:5).